

C O U C H H E R O E S

Organizational Design

Staffing Roadmap & Structure Alternatives

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What We'll Cover

PART ONE

Where We Are & Where We're Going

- Current team snapshot — 50 people, experience & gaps
- Current org charts by department — who's here, who's missing
- Hiring phase color-coding — when each open role gets filled
- Development phase timeline — Early Prod through Live Ops
- Headcount growth curve — 50 → 70+ trajectory

PART TWO

How Should We Organize?

- Model A — Optimized Functional (org chart + analysis)
- Model B — Hybrid Matrix (org chart + analysis)
- Model C — Outcome-Based Pillars (org chart + analysis)
- Side-by-side comparison matrix
- Recommendation & evolution path

Current Team Snapshot

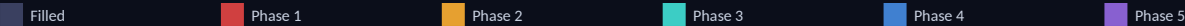


Critical Gaps Identified

- No Executive Producer — production leadership void
 - No CTO with shipped MMO experience
 - No Lead Level Designer or Lead Game Designer
 - No dedicated Art or Tech Producers
- No network engineering capability (critical for MMO)
 - No DevOps / CI-CD infrastructure
 - QA is single-person with no automation
 - Art Director span: 6 teams, 25+ reports (unsustainable)

Experience & Tenure Risk

Of the 19 key tracked roles, 10 have under 3 years in their role type and 8 have under 5 years total workforce experience. The team skews junior — particularly in Engineering (gameplay) and Art (characters, animation). Senior hires in Phases 1-2 aren't optional; they're load-bearing for the juniors already here.



Studio Overview — Current Structure

Filled

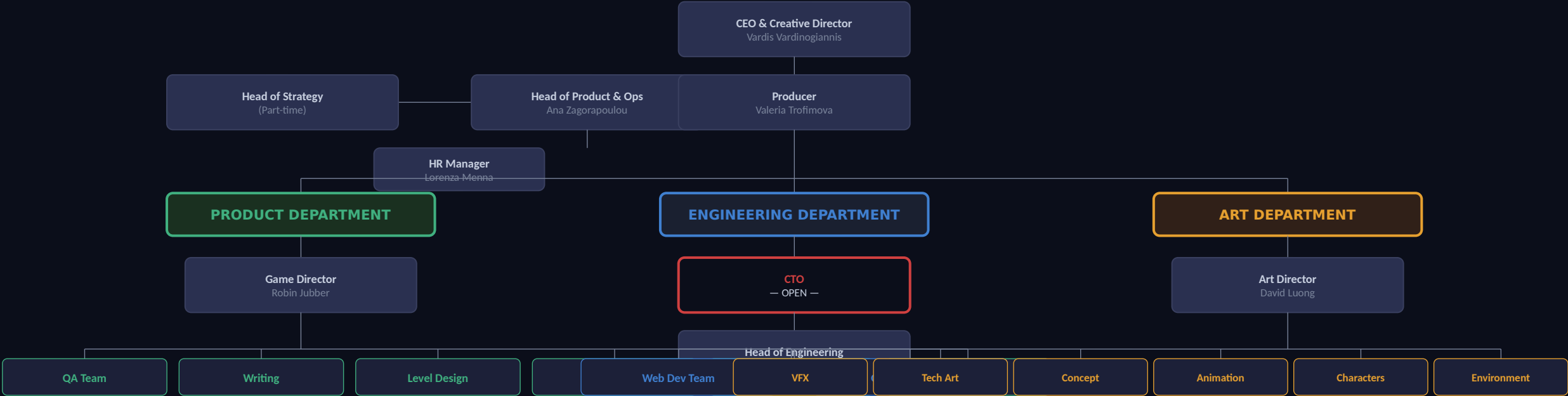
Phase 1

Phase 2

Phase 3

Phase 4

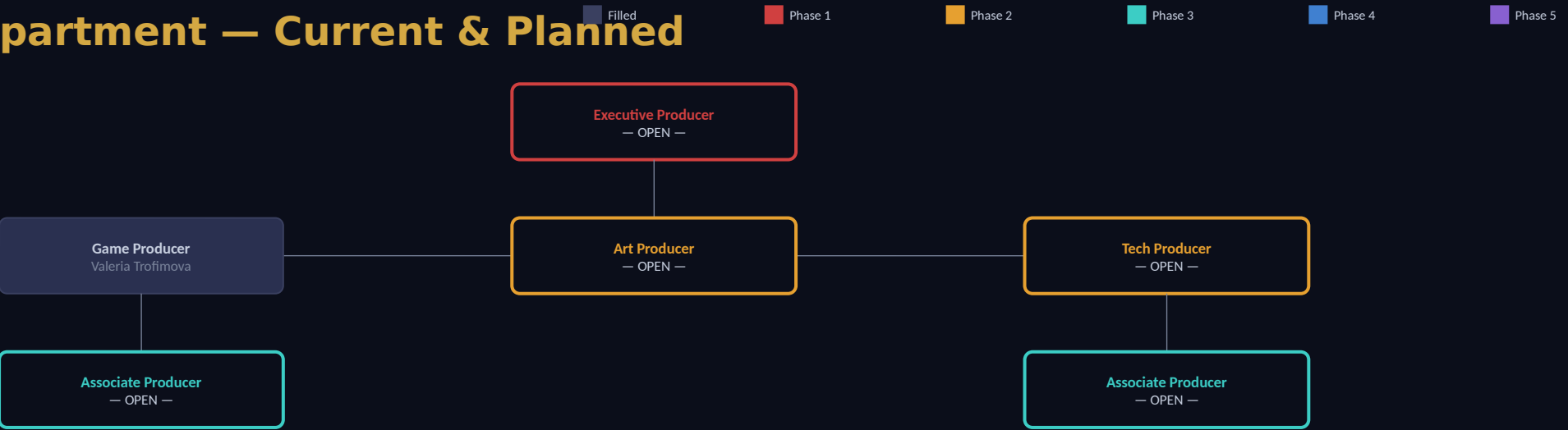
Phase 5



Key Structural Issues

- Art Director manages 6 sub-teams (25+ people) — span of control is unsustainable
- No Executive Producer — Producer role lacks cross-department authority
- CTO position open — Engineering lacks strategic technical leadership
- Game Director manages 6 sub-teams including QA — needs dedicated leads
- No producers embedded in Art or Engineering — coordination through goodwill only

Production Department — Current & Planned



Production Coverage

Game Producer → Product Teams

- Level Design Team (Lead + 4 designers + Tech Designer)
- Game Design Team (Lead + Combat Designer + Jr Designer)
- QA Team (Lead + tester)
- Writing Team (Jr Writer)
- Sound Design (Audio Lead + 2)
- UX/UI (Lead + Jr Graphic Designer)

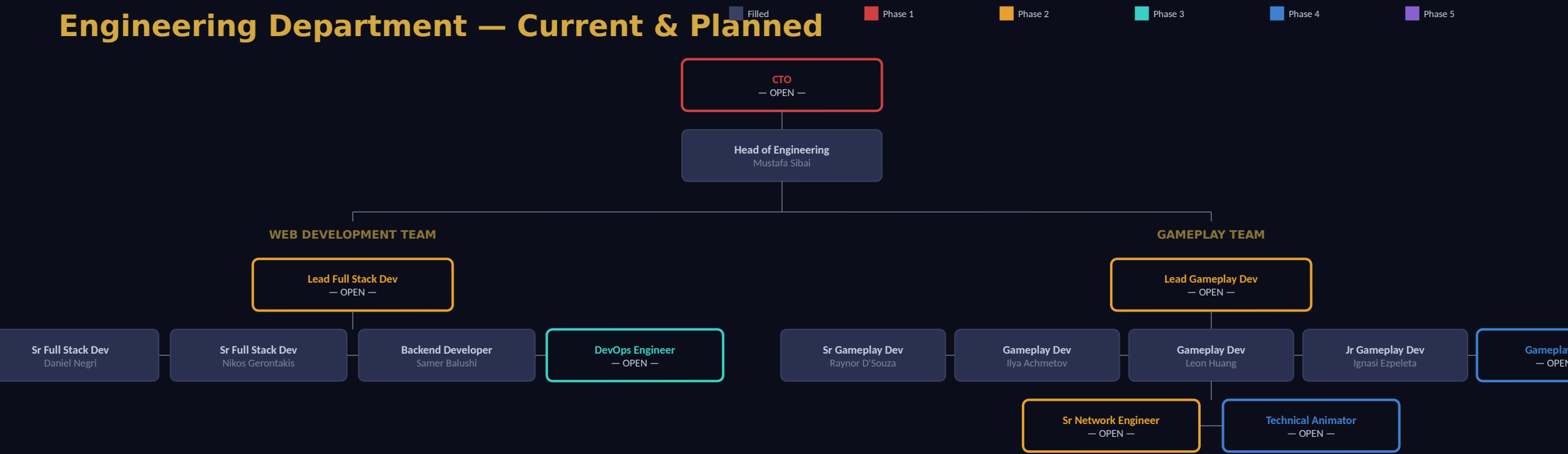
Art Producer → Art Teams

- VFX Team (Lead + 3 juniors)
- Technical Art (Lead + 2 juniors)
- Concept Art (Lead + 5 artists)
- 3D Animation (Lead + rigger + animator)
- 3D Characters (Lead + 2 juniors)
- 3D Environment (Lead + 5 artists)

Tech Producer → Engineering Teams

- Web Development (Lead + 2 Sr + Backend)
- Gameplay Team (Lead + Sr + 3 devs + Jr)
- DevOps / CI-CD pipeline
- Network Engineering
- Technical Animation

Engineering Department — Current & Planned



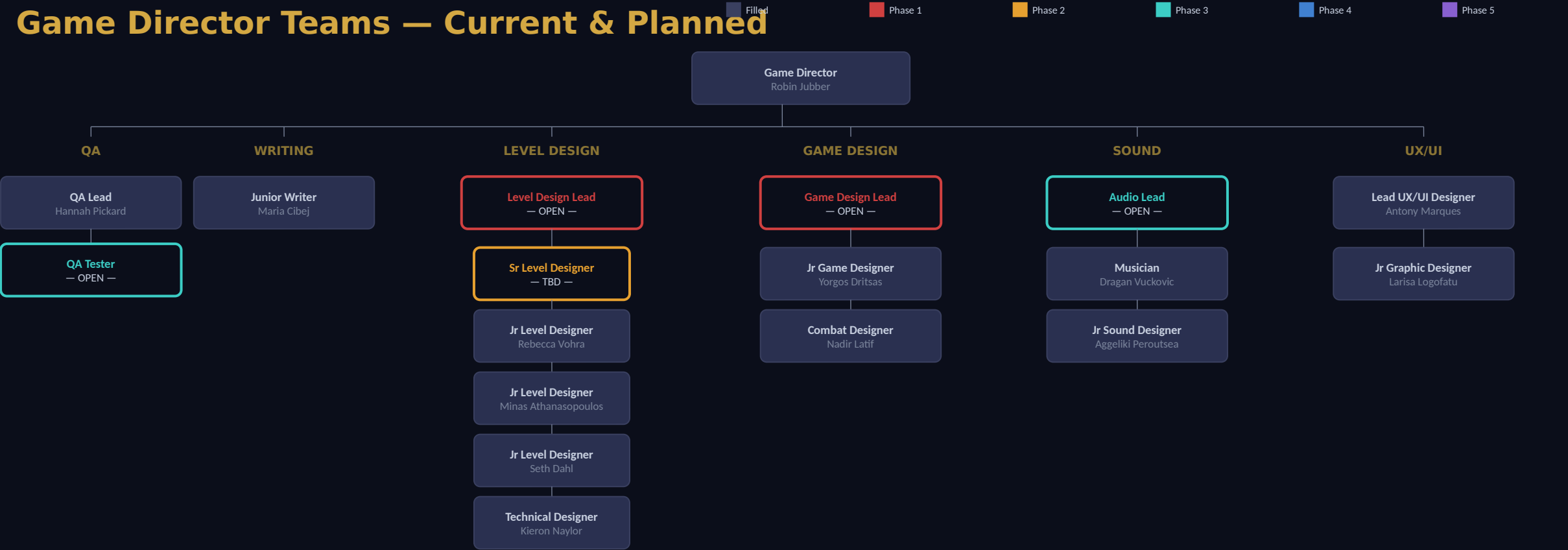
CTO Requirements

- 10+ years experience
- 3-5 shipped games
- 1+ live service title
- MMO/multiplayer architecture
- Team scaling experience

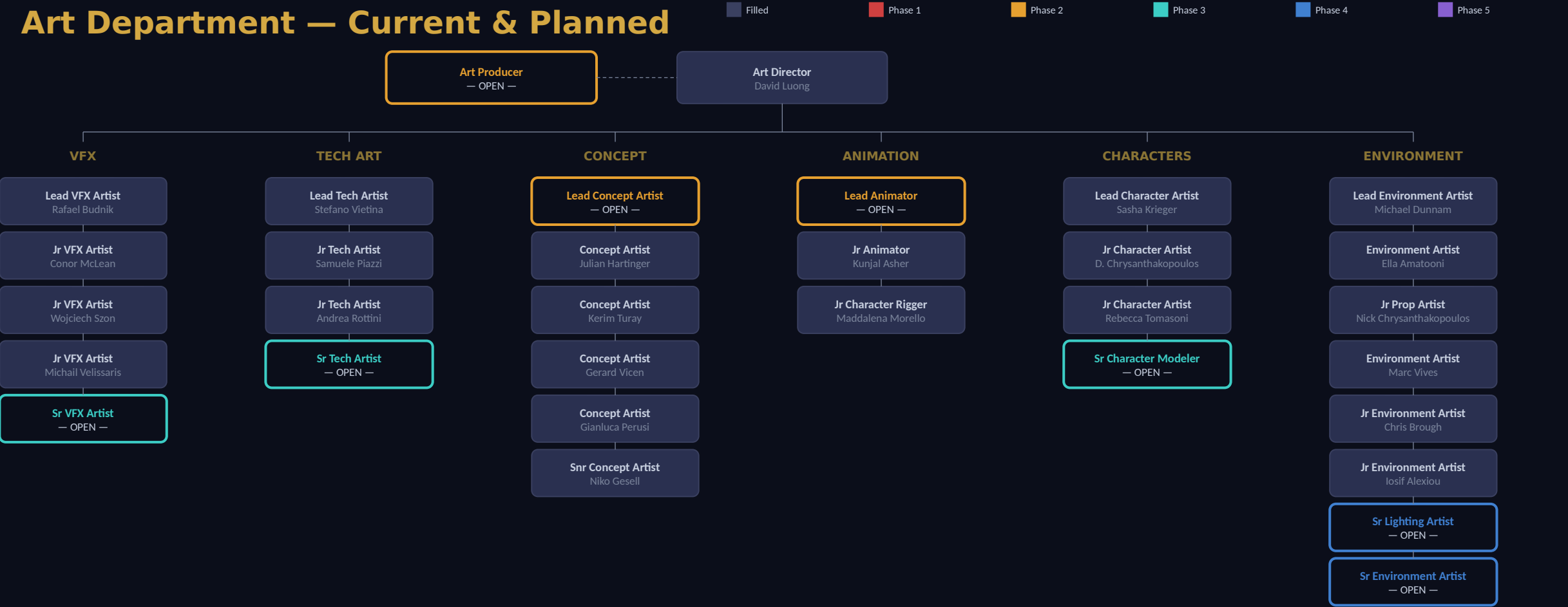
Critical Gaps

- No CTO — strategic tech leadership absent
- No Lead Full Stack — web team self-managing
- No DevOps — no CI/CD pipeline
- No network engineer — MMO-critical gap
- Head of Eng has 10+ reports directly

Game Director Teams — Current & Planned



Art Department — Current & Planned



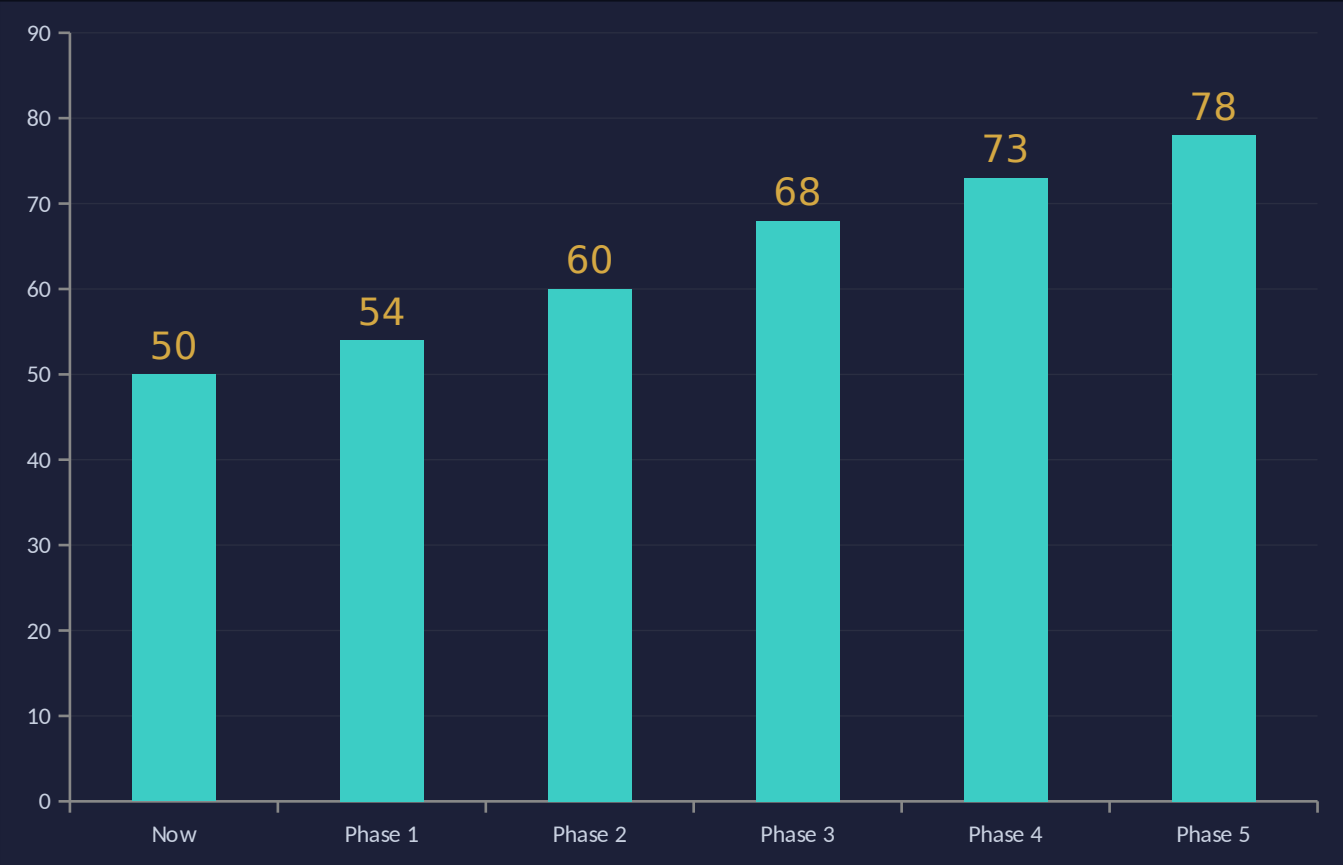
⚠️ Art Director spans 6 teams, 25+ people — unsustainable without Art Producer

Staffing Plan by Development Phase

Phase 1 Immediate	Phase 2 Near-Term	Phase 3 Mid-Production	Phase 4 Alpha / Beta	Phase 5 Launch / Live
Executive Producer	Art Producer	DevOps Engineer	Sr Environment Artist	Live Ops Producer
CTO / Tech Director	Tech Producer	Assoc Producer (Game)	Sr Lighting Artist	Data Analyst
Lead Level Designer	Lead Concept Artist	Assoc Producer (Tech)	Gameplay Developer	Server Infra Engineer
Game Design Lead	Lead Animator	Sr VFX Artist	Technical Animator	Content Designers (x2)
	Lead Full Stack Dev	Sr Character Modeler	Community Manager	Customer Support Lead
	Sr Network Engineer	QA Tester		
		Audio Lead		
		Sr Tech Artist		
4 roles	6 roles	8 roles	5 roles	5 roles

Total new hires across all phases: ~28 roles

Headcount Growth Trajectory



Growth Rate

56% increase over the full dev cycle. Most aggressive growth in Phases 1-3 (leadership + pipeline roles).

Art-Heavy Profile

Art remains the largest department at every phase. Art Producer hire in Phase 2 is critical to manage span.

Engineering Gap

Engineering is undersized for an MMO. Network engineer and DevOps are non-negotiable for multiplayer infrastructure.

Live Ops Prep

Phase 5 hires are forward-looking — without live ops capability at launch, the game dies in month 3.

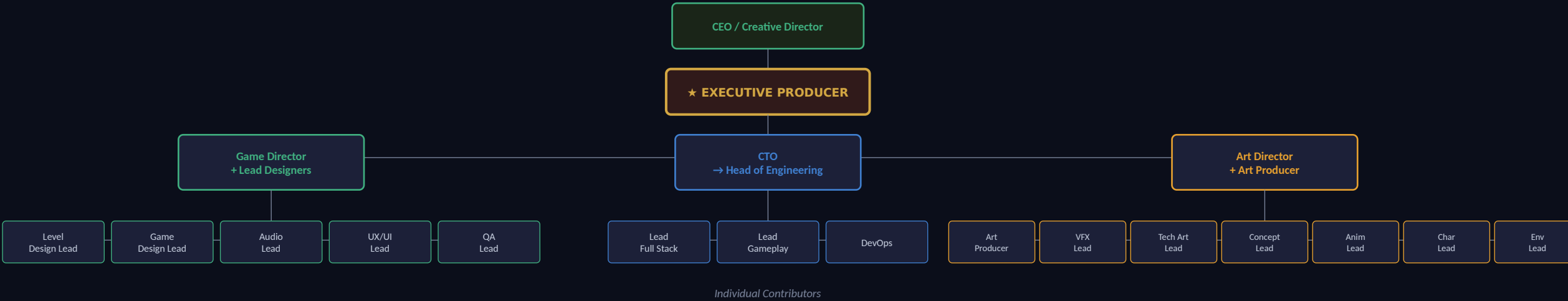
PART TWO

How Should We Organize?

Three structure alternatives for a 70-person MMO studio

Optimized Functional

LOW DISRUPTION
2-3 weeks



What Changes

- Install Executive Producer with real cross-department authority
- Add Art Producer and Tech Producer as intermediate management
- Fill missing Lead roles (Level Design, Game Design, Full Stack, Concept, Animator)
- Art Director span drops from 25+ to ~10 (Art Producer takes production load)

Strengths

- Least disruptive (2-3 weeks)
- Clear career paths via departments
- Strongest craft quality ownership

Weaknesses

- Cross-department friction persists
- EP becomes single coordination bottleneck
- Scaling to 100+ escalates overhead

Precedent: Most traditional game studios

Model B

Hybrid Matrix

MEDIUM DISRUPTION

4-6 weeks



Strengths

- Pods slash handoff friction — features ship end-to-end
- Career paths remain clear through discipline departments
- Adding new pods is straightforward — scales naturally
- Used by Riot, Bungie, and successful mid-size studios

Weaknesses

- Dual reporting creates confusion (RACI essential)
- Discipline leads may feel authority is diminished
- Requires strong EP to balance pod priorities
- 4-6 weeks of disruption during transition

Outcome-Based Pillars

HIGH DISRUPTION
6-10 weeks

CRAFT GUARDIANS

CTO
Engineering quality

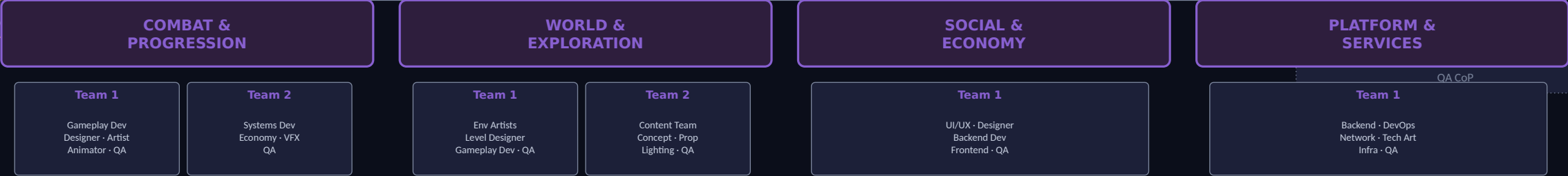
Art Director
Art quality

COMMUNITIES OF PRACTICE

Art CoP

Engineering CoP

QA CoP



Strengths

- Maximum velocity — no handoffs, no coordination overhead
- Excellent span of control (flat, small teams of 5-9)
- Scales by adding teams to pillars — natural for MMO
- Highest team autonomy and ownership

Weaknesses

- Highest disruption — 6-10 weeks, significant cultural change
- Career paths less clear (needs leveling framework)
- Craft quality can drift without rigorous CoP maintenance
- Requires extremely strong Pillar Leads

Precedent: Supercell cell structure, Chris Casanova framework

Side-by-Side Comparison

Dimension	Model A: Functional	Model B: Hybrid Matrix	Model C: Pillars
Implementation time	2-3 weeks	4-6 weeks	6-10 weeks
Handoff friction	Reduced but persists	Significantly reduced	Eliminated
Feature delivery speed	Moderate improvement	Significant improvement	Maximum
Craft quality control	Strongest	Strong (CoPs)	Requires active mgmt
Career path clarity	Clearest	Clear (dual track)	Needs leveling framework
Scaling to 100+	Coordination costs rise	Add pods naturally	Add teams to pillars
EP dependency	High (bottleneck)	Medium (pods self-manage)	Lower (pillar leads)
Cultural change	Minimal	Moderate	Significant
Risk of failure	Low	Medium	Medium-High
Best precedent	Traditional studios	Riot, Bungie	Supercell, Casanova

Recommendation

Start with Model B. Evolve toward Model C.

Model B delivers cross-functional delivery benefits without the risk of a full restructure during a growth phase. It gives the incoming EP a clear command structure, while setting the foundation to evolve toward fully autonomous teams as the studio matures.

Evolution Path

Now → 3 Months

Implement Model A fixes immediately

Add missing leads, install EP, fix Art Director span. These are urgent regardless of model.

3 → 6 Months

Transition to Model B pods

Once EP onboarded and leads in place, overlay delivery pods. Start with 2-3 pods on highest-priority features.

6+ Months

Evaluate Model C evolution

If pods thriving and team ready, begin dissolving departments in favor of pillars. Optional — B is a viable end state.

Key Dependencies:

EP hired and onboarded · CTO in place · Lead roles filled · RACI defined · Production framework piloted

Next Steps

0 Align on organizational model

1 Vardis and leadership team select preferred structure (A, B, or C) and confirm evolution timeline.

0 Hire Executive Producer + CTO

2 These are load-bearing roles. No structural change is viable without them in place. Target: 8-12 weeks.

0 Fill Lead roles (Phase 1-2)

3 Level Design Lead, Game Design Lead, Lead Full Stack Dev, Art Producer, Tech Producer. Each unblocks downstream hires.

0 Define RACI & decision rights

4 For Model B/C: clarify who owns delivery vs. craft vs. career decisions. Publish and socialize before any reorg.

0 Pilot production framework

5 Test the chosen operating rhythm with 1-2 teams before studio-wide rollout. Iterate based on feedback.